

Contentious politics in the borderlands: How nonviolence and migrant characteristics affect public attitudes

Journal of Peace Research

2025, Vol. 62(4) 995–1012

© The Author(s) 2024

Article reuse guidelines:

sagepub.com/journals-permissions

DOI: 10.1177/00223433241271872

journals.sagepub.com/home/jpr**Pearce Edwards** *Department of Political Science, Louisiana State University, USA***Daniel Arnon***School of Government and Public Policy, University of Arizona, USA*

Abstract

New political issues and opportunities lead new actors into contentious politics. This article studies one such case: transnational migrants making claims and engaging in collective action when traversing state borders. As global migration flows and accompanying political backlash has grown since the mid-2010s, borders have increasingly become sites of contention between groups of migrants seeking entry and state agents attempting to refuse it. Media coverage and elite discourse also has focused on contentious border crossings, with implications for public attitudes toward migration. In this setting, public attitudes toward migrants should vary based on the migrants' tactics and characteristics. We expect migrants engaging in nonviolent resistance to security forces will win more public support than those engaging in violence. Migrant characteristics – claims or motives for migration and ethnic identity – should also affect support. Survey experiments in the United States and Mexico containing fictionalized vignettes of a contentious event at the countries' shared land border show strikingly similar results: migrant nonviolent resistance, compared to violent confrontations, reduces support for deportation and increases beliefs that migrants contribute to society. These effects are consistent across party lines and border proximity. Neither migrants' claims nor migrants' ethnic identity affect public support in the context of a contentious event.

Keywords

borders, contentious politics, identity, migration, nonviolence

Introduction

Contentious events, in which non-state actors make claims against governments, and episodes of political violence are not static political processes. New issues and opportunities motivate previously unmobilized individuals and groups to participate in contention (Steinert-Threlkeld, 2017; Pearlman, 2021), shifting coalitions of claim-making groups prompt tactical innovation (Cunningham et al., 2017; Wang and Soule, 2016), and participation in contention awakens participants' political identities and agency (Klandermans and Van Stekelenburg, 2019; Pop-Eleches et al., 2022).

This article examines the varying tactics and characteristics of a type of actor increasingly exercising agency through contention: migrants. As globalization deepened in the early 21st century, political issues emerged that motivated claim-making by newly politicized actors such as transnational migrants. From denouncing repression by security forces at the Mexico–USA border in which US Border Patrol agents reportedly used 'whip-like cords' to disperse crowds, to demonstrations demanding

Corresponding author:pedwards1@lsu.edu

asylum in European capitals, migrants make high-profile claims for freedom of movement and political inclusion. These claims receive public attention – and mixed support – in the countries through and to which migrants travel (Hangartner et al., 2019; Madrigal and Soroka, 2023). Under what conditions does contentious action win migrants public support for their claims?

We draw on insights from contentious politics to explain how, in the context of border crossings, variation in migrants' tactics and characteristics affects public support. We make two related arguments. First, after providing evidence that migrants increasingly participate in contentious events, we contend the tactics they choose when making claims should affect public attitudes (Edwards and Arnon, 2021; Manekin and Mitts, 2022; Wasow, 2020). Migrants exercise agency in their use of tactics when making claims for freedom of movement across borders. They may engage in nonviolent resistance – encamping along a border, peacefully protesting, or not complying with state agents – or they may violently resist agents who seek to enforce prohibitions against undocumented border crossings. We argue that encampments are more likely to win public support than confrontations with security forces.

Our second argument focuses on the background characteristics of migrants involved in contentious events. These are largely outside migrants' agency. Because migration induces public perceptions of cultural threat, we argue that contention in which migrants profess political loyalty to the destination country (Wright and Citrin, 2011) – rather than economic motives – are more likely to blunt this threat and increase public support. We also expect that less racialized migrant ethnic identities will receive increased support (Manekin and Mitts, 2022; Ostfeld, 2017). Together, these arguments suggest that how migrants choose to express their claims is just as important for shaping public attitudes as who migrants are.

To test the argument's implications, we conduct survey experiments in both the United States and Mexico, studying public attitudes in response to contentious events at the two countries' shared land border. Each survey presents respondents with a vignette about an encounter between migrants and security forces from the United States Border Patrol near the border town of Brownsville, Texas. A factorial design randomly exposes respondents to varying information about migrants' tactics, claims, and ethnic identity. We expect nonviolent tactics, political claims, and less racialized out-group identities to generate more public support for the migrants and for liberalized immigration policy

compared to violent tactics, economic claims, and more racialized out-group identities. Given our theoretical focus on migration as a context of contention, each treatment estimates the opinion effects of variation within a contentious event involving migrants, rather than comparing contentious events to non-events involving migrants.

Results of the two survey experiments are strikingly similar. Migrant nonviolent resistance in contentious border events – compared to violent confrontations – decreases respondents' general support for deportation of undocumented migrants and increases the belief that migrants make a positive contribution to society. We show the effects of migrant nonviolent resistance are consistent regardless of migrant ethnic identity, respondents' partisanship, and respondents' proximity to the border. The results affirm the importance of nonviolent tactics for winning public support, and show the applicability of these tactics to a set of actors less studied in literature on contentious politics. In contrast with their tactics, and contrary to our expectations, migrants' claims and ethnic identities do not affect public support for deportation or attitudes about migrants' contributions to society. Our results suggest that migrants exercising agency in their tactical choices can compensate for migrant characteristics that might otherwise decrease support.

This article makes several contributions to literature on contentious politics and migration. First, it defines migration as a context of contentious events – showing that migrants consciously engage in collective action and claim-making. In this way, the project builds on work from sociology and anthropology which began to understand migrants as increasing participants in contention, with the use of varying tactics in the pursuit of claims for freedom of movement and asylum (Rosenberger et al., 2018; Steinhilper, 2018; Volk, 2021). In empirical political science, only a handful of studies, such as Wright and Citrin (2011), connect migration with contentious political action.

Second, the article adds to literature studying how aspects of contentious actors and events affect public opinion. These actors' tactics (violent vs. nonviolent) (Chenoweth and Stephan, 2011) and (non-)racialized identities (Davenport et al., 2011) are powerful influences on how collective action is perceived and whether it receives support. More recent work studies variation in tactics and identities simultaneously, suggesting that nonviolent tactics' effectiveness and perceived legitimacy varies with the identities of contentious actors (Chenoweth and Cunningham, 2023; Edwards and Arnon, 2021; Manekin and Mitts, 2022). Our findings,

at least in the context of outcomes related to migration policy, suggest that variation in racialized identity has no detectable effect on attitudes toward migrants as contentious actors. This suggests that an overarching migrant identity may outweigh – perceptually – variation in (non-)racialized identities, and underscores how the context of contentious events can shape their effects.

Third, by studying public attitudes toward migrant claim-making, we add to past research on public opinion on migration. A common explanation in this literature is the salience to the public of cultural threat and other sociotropic concerns about the arrival of migrants (Getmansky et al., 2019; Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Ostfeld, 2017; Valentino et al., 2019). Our findings suggest migrant characteristics that decrease public support in abstract settings detached from the act of migration matter less – or perhaps not at all – when contextualized in a contentious border event. In this way, we incorporate the means by which migrants cross borders into this literature (Madrigal and Soroka, 2023).

Migrants as contentious actors

From the early 21st century migrants increasingly engaged in contentious politics. Before providing evidence for this claim, however, we define concepts. The term *migrant* is fraught with normative connotations and empirical subtlety. Some INGOs, such as Amnesty International, distinguish migrants from asylum seekers and refugees, with the former traversing state borders for non-political reasons. Asylum seekers, meanwhile, are defined as those who petition for legal recognition as refugees: escapees from political persecution or human rights violations in their home countries (McKay et al., 2012). By contrast, we follow the definition of scholars such as Steinhilper (2018: 15), who use the term *migrant* ‘in an inclusive sense [. . .] in order to avoid the misleading and highly consequential dichotomy between “economic migrants” and “refugees”’.¹ Thus, a transnational migrant is an umbrella term for an individual moving or seeking movement across state borders, and does not impute motive (asylum seeker vs. economic migrant) or condition on legal recognition (refugee).

We study migrants in the setting of *contentious politics*. McAdam et al. (2001: 5) define contentious politics as ‘episodic, public, collective interaction among makers of claims and their objects when (a) at least one government is a claimant, an object of claims, or a party to the claims, and (b) the claims would, if realized, affect the interests of at least one of the claimants’. In particular, we identify

migrants as the makers of claims and governments as the object of the claims. The claims migrants make of governments usually relate to freedom of movement and humane treatment by state agents. Migrants make these claims from physical locations: transit routes, border crossings, and camps. Migrant claimmaking is therefore not unique in its basic pattern from other claim-making activity: labor unions demanding wage increases with work stoppages, social movements calling for policy concessions during protests, or human rights organizations naming and shaming repressive governments. The setting of contentious politics studies migration from the vantage point of an interaction between migrants and state (e.g. Hangartner et al. (2019)), rather than as a state-centered policy choice (e.g. Hainmueller and Hopkins (2014)).

Evidence of migrant claim-making

Migrant claim-making at the Mexico–USA border received increased attention in the late 2010s. A group of more than 1,000 Central American migrants sang protest songs as they walked north through Guatemala in 2018 (Abbott, 2018). In 2019, groups of migrants from sub-Saharan Africa protested their detention at a facility near Mexico’s southern border, holding signs in front of Mexican security forces (Lauvergnier, 2019). After a US federal judge let stand restrictive Trump-administration migration policies in May 2022, hundreds of migrants chanted in unison and held signs denouncing the closed border on the Mexican side of a US port of entry (Sieglar, 2022).

These are not isolated incidents. Protests by migrants, including contentious events escalating to riots, spiked with the start of the 2020s. Figure 1 depicts a count of the number of ACLED-documented protests and riots involving migrants, globally between 2018 and 2022 (Raleigh et al., 2010). These anecdotes and event data demonstrate that refugees and migrants entered contentious politics as a claim-maker from the 2010s onward. They make demands of the state, and often are able to galvanize support from the public.²

Despite evidence that migrants increasingly participate in contentious action, little research studies them from this perspective.³ It is not clear how migrant protest events or confrontations with state agents affect public attitudes toward migration. This article fills these gaps by combining insights on attitudes toward migration with existing literature on responses to contentious events.

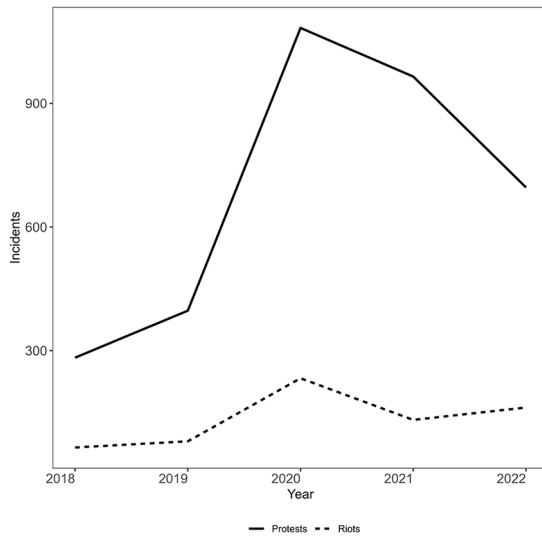


Figure 1. Number of ACLED-documented protests and riots involving migrants 2018–2022.

Migrant tactics: Nonviolent resistance

In contentious events involving migrants, aspects of these events should affect public attitudes – as is the case with contention generally. As groups of migrants carry out contentious actions, they employ certain tactics – techniques used to assert claims (Chenoweth, 2021). Participants' tactical choices are central features of contentious events. Yet, the effects of variation in tactics employed in contentious migration events are little studied, with exceptions such as Wright and Citrin (2011) with protests, and Sirin et al. (2016) in immigration detention centers.

Migrants employ a range of contentious tactics. One tactic is protest at borders, in which migrants enact established forms of protest including demonstrations, hunger strikes, and sit-ins. Migrants have also tactically innovated, using new and dramatic forms of peacefully making claims. These have included protesters sewing their mouths shut to signal their dire conditions and their political silencing (Villegas, 2022). At times, confrontations with state agents prompt the use of violent tactics, including throwing rocks and igniting fires. News reports indicate that migrants and refugees consciously regard the choice to engage in contention and seek consensus on their protest tactics (Bayly, 2022). How migrants make claims, similarly to other contentious actors, may have consequences for whether they receive public support and whether they can pressure the state to concede to their claims.

Physically threatening tactics that could lead to harm are likely to receive less public support than nonviolent

tactics (Edwards and Arnon, 2021; Wasow, 2020). Large groups of migrants portrayed as 'floods' or 'hordes' spilling over borders harden anti-migrant sentiment (Madrigal and Soroka, 2023), with the effects increasing when groups are larger (Hood and Morris, 1998). Physical threat such as confrontations between migrants and security forces can activate underlying fears of violence and crime that the public perceives migrants bring with them (Fitzgerald et al., 2012; Hellwig and Sinno, 2017). Individuals proximate to migrants experience these fears more acutely: 'specific, local' threats are more pronounced than those which appear more abstract (Ostfeld, 2017: 24).

Migrants' tactics that pose less physical threat – such as nonviolent resistance to security forces – are likely to receive more support than violent tactics. Contentious actions of this kind are seen as more legitimate and less deserving of a coercive response. Nonviolent resistance improves attitudes toward contentious actions regardless of citizens' prior beliefs about the actors involved: non-violence lowers barriers to support and gives contentious actors wider appeal than if they were threatening (Chenoweth and Stephan, 2011). Nonviolence's lower barriers to support stem from moral reasoning: public observers of contention evaluate nonviolent resistance, unlike violent resistance, as intrinsically just. Accordingly, one experimental study identified a 'substantial effect of nonviolent resistance on the tendency to support [. . .] join, and donate' to contentious actors (Dahlum et al., 2023: 347).

This produces our first hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1: During contentious actions at the border, tactics of nonviolent resistance increase support for migration and inclusion relative to threatening tactics.

Characteristics of migrants in contention

As a complement to migrant tactics, we consider two characteristics that literature on public attitudes toward migration suggests shapes attitudes. First, when migrants make claims, they may make different types of claims or justifications for freedom of movement. Second, there may also be varying identity groups involved in contentious events around migration.

Economic and political claims

Past literature has identified migrants' characteristics as explanations of public support for liberalized immigration

policy (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014). Experimental research has presented these characteristics to respondents in abstract settings detached from the act of migration. For example, Hainmueller and Hopkins (2015) present respondents with detailed profiles of hypothetical migrants. Hopkins (2015) shows a video of a migrant advocating for liberalized policy. The type of migrants' claims – i.e. their motives – and migrant ethnic identities are two frequent characteristics examined in this literature.

Political claims, including seeking asylum and legal refugee status under international conventions, may also be an emphasis of migrant contention. When migrants seek asylum or refugee status on the basis of facing political persecution in their origin countries, they receive more public support (Von Hermann and Neumann, 2019). One explanation for this favorability is migrants' signaled compatibility with the civic values of the destination country. These signals – especially during contentious actions – suggest 'loyalty to and affection for' that country and prime feelings of 'common identity' based on migrants' desired membership in the polity (Wright and Citrin, 2011: 326).

The public therefore conditions support for migrants on the distinction between political and economic claims. Political claims are perceived as more 'legitimate' and warranting inclusionary policies toward migrants, while economic claims reduce public support and advocacy for inclusionary policies (Onraet et al., 2021). The second hypothesis follows:

Hypothesis 2: During contentious actions at the border, emphasis on migrants' political claims increases support for migration and inclusion, as opposed to economic claims.

Out-group identities

Ethnic identities also shape public attitudes toward migrants as they do for other contentious actors (Davenport et al., 2011; Manekin and Mitts, 2022). The public racializes more distinct ethnic out-groups, directing less support toward these groups (Sirin et al., 2016; Valentino et al., 2019). In particular, migrants with darker skin color relative to light-skinned dominant ethnic groups in these countries face more racialization (Flores and Schachter, 2018; Ostfeld, 2017).⁴ Ethnic out-groups in turn trigger perceptions of cultural threat, which works in tandem with racial othering to generate xenophobia (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; McKay et al., 2012). Othering facilitates the dehumanization of

its targets while driving up support for policies that coerce and repress them (Maoz and McCauley, 2008).

By contrast, emphasizing contention by migrants from less racialized out-groups generates comparably more support. Like political claim-making, migrants who are more similar to a country's dominant ethnic groups are seen as more compatible with membership in that society. Such ethnic favoritism also takes on emotional significance, undercutting the anger and fear associated with perceived cultural threats from out-groups (Sides and Citrin, 2007: 479).

If migrants' racialized out-group status relative to a country's dominant ethnic group is similar, then we should expect comparable effects of identity variation across countries. The third hypothesis results:

Hypothesis 3: During contentious actions at the border, emphasis on migrants' less racialized ethnic identity increases support for migration and inclusion, as opposed to more racialized identities.

Empirical setting: Contention at the Mexico–USA border

We test these hypotheses in the setting of the Mexico–United States land border, focusing on migrant contention on the Rio Grande River where it divides the US state of Texas and the Mexican states of Tamaulipas and Coahuila. This segment of the border is a focal point for migrants traversing Mexico and attempting to reach the United States. Encounters – interactions between the United States Border Patrol and migrants that include apprehensions and expulsions – have consistently increased since 2009. In 2021 alone, the Border Patrol's most easterly land-based territory, the Rio Grande Sector, witnessed a 509% increase in migrant encounters over 2020.⁵ The Del Rio sector, just upriver, saw a 543% increase in attempted migrant entries in the same period. In all, 2021 set records for the highest number of migrant encounters since encounters have been tracked (Gramlich and Scheller, 2021).

In the same year, the Rio Grande and Del Rio border sectors received attention in both the United States and Mexico because some encounters between migrants and the US Border Patrol developed into high-profile contentious events. In September, a group of migrants – primarily Haitian – reached the border in the Del Rio sector. During collective attempts to ford the river from Mexico to the United States, migrants confronted US Border Patrol agents on horseback who used crowd control measures to disperse them. Public controversy seethed over how

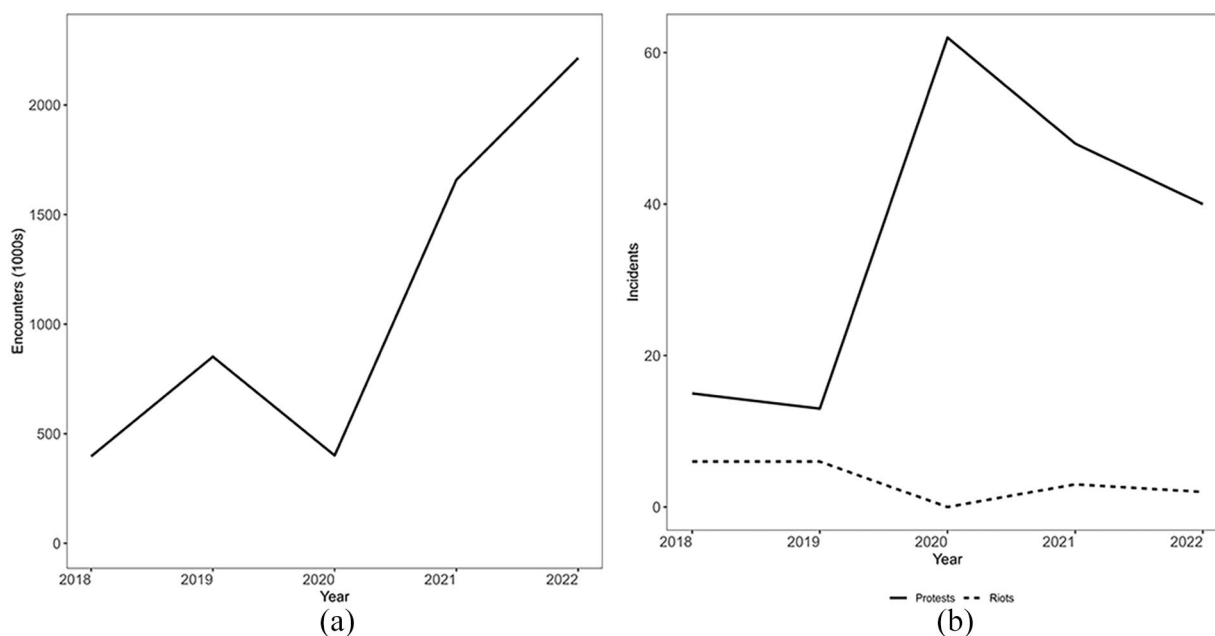


Figure 2. Migrant encounters (a) and protests and riots (b) at US-Mexico land border 2018-2022.

agents had possibly used ‘whip-like cords’ in their efforts (Solomon, 2021). Simultaneously, more nonviolent migrant actions occurred: large encampments of migrants under bridges awaited the opportunity to file asylum claims in the United States (Dobbins et al., 2021). During these events, migrants revealed a burgeoning sense of collective, contentious identity. Solomon (2021) quoted one migrant declaring that ‘the government of the United States has no conscience’ in the midst of contention with Border Patrol agents.

Figure 2 depicts trends in migrant encounters and contentious events at the Mexico–United States land border from 2018 to 2022. The left panel (a) shows migrant encounters reported by the United States Border Patrol, which reached record levels in fiscal year 2021 and again in fiscal year 2022 – exceeding two million for the first time. Concurrently with this increase in migrants attempting to cross from Mexico into the United States has been an increase in contentious actions undertaken by migrants. The right panel (b) of the figure draws on data from ACLED, which began counting incidents of protest and political violence in the United States and Mexico in 2018. The two line graphs in the right panel track protests and riots, respectively, that involved migrants and occurred within 100 miles of the Mexico–USA border in both countries.

An example of a protest incident from the ACLED data reveals the sense of political identity and conscious exercise of agency in choosing tactics around focal events such as funerals:

On 4 June 2022, in Tijuana, Baja California, more than 100 Haitian migrants protested to demand justice and more security after the death of two Haitian migrants. The demonstrators also protested against the immigration policies of the United States and Mexico. The demonstration took place during the burial held for the two dead migrants.

An example of a riot incident from the same data – though much less frequent than protests – shows the dynamic interaction between security forces and migrants that characterize contentious events:

On 31 October 2022, at the border between Ciudad Juarez, Chihuahua and Texas, more than 100 Venezuelan migrants demonstrated to demand their entry into the U.S. on the banks of the Rio Bravo [Rio Grande] carrying a flag of the U.S. to seek dialogue with the border authorities. The migrants tried to cross the river into the U.S., when the U.S. Border Patrol intervened and shot rubber bullets, injuring at least one individual. The migrants returned to Mexico. According to Customs and Border Protection officials, some of the demonstrators began throwing stones at the Border Patrol guards, and injured one CBP officer with a flag pole.

In this context of contentious border encounters, public attitudes on migration in the United States and Mexico is divided. In Mexico in a 2019 survey, 64% of respondents believed migrants from Central America traversing the country to be an economic burden, 55% favored their deportation to countries of origin, and 51%

avored using the Mexican National Guard to combat migration within the country's borders. Respondents were also receptive to President Lopez Obrador: 42% regularly watched his press conferences, and only 27% disapproved of his handling of migration (Washington Post-Reforma, 2019). Attitudes toward migration in the United States in 2020 were similarly divided. Three-quarters of survey respondents believed undocumented migrants should be permitted to stay in the United States provided a legal pathway existed to their residency, and a similar share supported granting permanent residency to migrants who arrived to the United States as children (Pew Research, 2020). These divisions – particularly in the United States – tend to split along partisan lines; migration became a salient partisan issue on both sides of the border under Donald Trump's 2016–2020 presidency.

Research design

To test our hypotheses about migrant contentious action and its effects on public support, we conduct two survey experiments. Survey experiments with vignettes are a common and beneficial way to draw inferences about dynamic and multi-faceted contentious events: respondents read information with emphasis on different dimensions of content as they would when reading news articles. The survey experiments and main hypothesis tests were preregistered with Open Science Framework (OSF).⁶

USA and Mexico surveys

We fielded two surveys to test our hypotheses, one in the United States and one in Mexico. We conduct experiments on both sides of the Mexico–USA border for three reasons. First, the scope conditions for the argument apply in both countries. The proposed mechanism of threat, both physical and cultural, perceived from a contentious event depends neither on migrants' duration spent in a country nor their destination. Rather, the occurrence of a contentious event involving migrants in or adjacent to a country – as the treatment vignettes below describe – should be sufficient to trigger the threat mechanisms. To ensure each experimental design estimates parallel treatment effects, we remove from question wording any country-specific information. For example, our dependent variables measuring support for inclusion do not refer to inclusion in a particular country, but rather measure attitudes toward deporting migrants to their countries of origin.

Second, the comparability of the threat mechanisms between the two countries contrasts the contentious politics approach with other work on migration. In the experimental treatment vignettes, Mexico is a transit country for migrants, while the United States is a destination country. Migration research often builds distinct arguments for how destination and transit countries shape or respond to migration (e.g. Hangartner et al. (2019) and Zhou and Grossman (2021)), and how individuals both proximate and distant from migration react to it (e.g. Pinson and Simmons (2022) and Cortina (2020)). The contentious politics approach we take expects commonalities between destination and transit countries, and – conditional on media exposure to events – expects similar effects on proximate and distant individuals. Third, the USA and Mexico are crucial cases for testing hypotheses about contentious politics in the context of migration. The rise of contention and political violence in the United States since the mid-2010s has increased attention to the case (Chenoweth and Cunningham, 2023) even as migration also increased over the same period. For Mexico, attitudes toward criminal violence have been well studied in recent work, but there is little experimental evaluation of Mexicans' attitudes toward migration.

Data

The survey firm Lucid collected both samples. The sample from the US survey contained 4,028 completed adult respondents representative of age and gender breakdowns in the US Census. Respondents were block-sampled on their proximity to the Mexico–USA border to improve our ability to test for heterogeneous effects by proximity. The survey was in the field from 6 July to 14 July 2022. The sample from the Mexico survey contained 4,158 completed adult respondents representative of age and gender based on the Mexican census. There was similar blocking on border proximity: 70% of respondents (representative in the 18–55 age range) were targeted from the general population, and 30% of respondents (representative in the 18–45 age range) were targeted in border states. The survey was in the field from 6 July to 1 August 2022. Descriptive statistics for the sample from each survey are in Tables SI.B.1 and SI.B.2 in the Online Appendix.

Several tests in each survey affirm the quality of the data and validity of the responses. In both surveys, respondents under the age of 18 and who failed an attention check were screened out at the pre-treatment stage.

We also test for differential attrition rates across treatment groups, and fail to reject the null hypothesis that treatment has no effect on missingness in outcome variables. We also fail to reject the null for differential attrition rates across treatment groups. Figure SI.B.1 depicts the results of these tests.

Treatment arms

After answering pretreatment questions, respondents are exposed to a fictionalized news story describing a contentious event involving migrants and the US Border Patrol in the Rio Grande sector of the Mexico–USA border. The ‘whip-like cords’ event involving Haitian migrants and security forces in September 2021 provided a template for the story, as well as border confrontations between agents and migrants near San Diego, California in November 2018.⁷ We opt not to include a pure control condition in which respondents are not exposed to a news story about a contentious event. The objective of the design is to estimate the effects on public attitudes of varying aspects of a contentious event involving migrants, rather than to test the effects of variation in the existence of migrant contention on those attitudes.

The content of the fictionalized news story, therefore, varies along three dimensions in line with our hypotheses. First, drawing on actual events at the Mexico–USA border, we vary migrants’ tactical choice in their contentious action. In the *encampment* condition, migrants are described as not threatening security forces, instead pitching tents and shelters along the border and taking refuge under a highway overpass. The migrants are also portrayed as nonviolent: waiting to learn about the outcome of an asylum claim and presenting their claims to visiting journalists. In the *confrontation* condition, migrants are described as crossing the Rio Grande River into the United States as a group, then throwing rocks and objects at US Border Patrol agents upon finding the passage blocked.⁸ To underscore the physical threat this tactic poses, the story mentions injuries agents received from projectiles, including one agent needing medical attention.

Second, we vary whether the migrants make *economic* or *political* claims. In the economic claims condition, the migrants lament the poor economy in their country of origin, and indicate they hope to find employment in the United States. To amplify the suggestion of economic motivations, a leader of the migrant group is quoted making the claim, and suggests it is a claim shared by other members of the group as well as other migrants which preceded him. In the political claims condition,

the migrants describe repression and government violation of physical integrity rights in their origin countries. A leader of the migrant group is quoted as asserting that the freedoms guaranteed in the US Constitution will protect their civil liberties upon entering the country, unlike in the group’s country of origin.

Third, we vary migrants’ ethnic identity. To accentuate migrants’ out-group status relative to the majority ethnic group in the United States and Mexico (white and mestizo, respectively), we vary both their ethnic background and country of origin simultaneously. This approach is consistent with other research on migration attitudes toward racialized outgroups (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015). In the more racialized out-group, or *Haiti*, condition, the group of migrants are identified as being from Haiti. The leader of the migrant group is given a common Haitian name, and self-describes his group as Black. This operationalization of a racialized out-group as Black Haitian is valid given the finding in Ostfeld (2017: 32) that migrants with ‘Afrocentric’ features are more racialized than other migrants in the United States, including those from Latin America. This is also consistent with evidence of racial discrimination against Haitian migrants in Mexico (Brewer et al., 2022). Accordingly, in the less racialized out-group, or *Central America* condition, the group of migrants are identified as traveling from Honduras. The leader of the migrant group receives a common Honduran name, and self-describes his group as Hispanic. In both cases the migrants’ region of origin is mentioned three times in the fictionalized news story.

Table 1 presents the fictionalized news story for the economic/encampment/Central American condition. Table SI.F.1 presents the treatment arms comprehensively in the Online Appendix. A headline opening the story (shown in the Online Appendix) also contains reference to all three of the treatment conditions.

One possible concern about the vignettes is that we added extra contextual detail around the nonviolent encampment and violent confrontation to increase realism. Adding contextual details is generally expected to reduce the magnitude of experimental treatment effects (Brutger et al., 2023). In our case, we include contextual details about participant gender. The nonviolent encampment treatment arm highlights the women participating in the event, increasing realism given the close empirical association between women’s participation in contention and nonviolence (Schafteenaar, 2017). The violent confrontation treatment arm mentions the young men participating in the event. Realism likewise increases in this case: men are closely associated with participation in

Table 1. Sample survey experiment vignette (economic, encampment, central American).

New details have emerged about an encampment of Central American migrants at the United States–Mexico border that developed last week near this Texas city.

According to sources, a large group of about 500 migrants – mainly women and children – pitched tents and other shelters along the Rio Grande River. Some set up camp under a highway bridge to stay out of the heat. The migrants waited to find out from the U.S. Border Patrol if they could seek asylum in the United States, or if they had to stay in Mexico while doing so.

A leader of the migrant group, 28-year-old Wilson Guerrero, spoke to reporters about the migrants' objectives. 'My home country has a very bad economy,' he said. 'It is very hard for us to find jobs, and earn money to support our families. I know there are many Hispanic people like us who have crossed this border and gotten good jobs that pay better than where we come from. I just hope the US government lets us enter.'

violent events. However, participant gender could activate the same mechanism as participant violence – physical threat – as findings such as those in Ward (2019) show that the public perceives young male migrants as security risks. Adding contextual realism to the vignettes about participant gender brings with it the risk of inflating treatment effects for this dimension of the treatment.

After reading the news story, respondents complete a manipulation check to ensure their comprehension of the story. We ask respondents to select which among four statements best describes the story content. These factual manipulation checks also monitor respondents' attention to the survey. Of those respondents who received treatment in the United States survey, only 6% incorrectly answered a factual manipulation check about the content of the vignette they read. In the Mexico survey, only 3% incorrectly answered the factual manipulation check.⁹

Dependent variables

The dependent variables of interest for testing our hypotheses are respondents' support for migration and support for inclusionary migration policies. Our measurement strategy for these variables is broadly consistent with measurement schemes for outcomes in studying responses to contentious events, focusing on attitudes towards the contentious actors themselves as well as broader policy prescriptions with relation to those actors. However, our outcomes relate specifically to migration and in this way diverge from studies of contentious action in non-migration contexts. The first dependent variable – *support for migration* – we measure as a five-point ordinal scale in response to the question: 'Do you agree or disagree with the following statement: migrants make a positive contribution to society', with 1 indicating strong disagreement, and 5 indicating strong agreement.

The second dependent variable – *support for inclusionary migration policies* – is inverted to ask for respondents' support for a policy of deporting undocumented migrants. This measurement strategy is more likely to measure consistent underlying attitudes given deportation's construct validity compared to more ambiguous inclusionary policies such as 'paths to citizenship'. Respondents read a five-point ordinal scale in response to the question: 'Do you agree or disagree with the following statement: migrants who cross a border illegally should be sent back to their home countries', with 1 indicating strong disagreement, and 5 indicating strong agreement.¹⁰

Covariates

We also ask, in the pretreatment period, a series of questions about respondents' demographic information – age, gender, level of education, ethnic identification, and income – as well as on potentially predictive social and political variables – party identification, news consumption patterns, political engagement, and a selection from a list of issues facing the country which they believe are most pressing (including migration). A full list of covariates is included with each of the full survey instruments in the Online Appendix.

Another important variable to measure is respondents' geographic location. In particular, when testing heterogeneous effects, this will allow us to identify whether our hypothesized effects are stronger or weaker if respondents are more proximate to the border – an important consideration in debates about whether contact with migrants increases or decreases support (Cortina, 2020; Fitzgerald et al., 2012). We construct two measures of proximity: a dichotomous indicator of whether a respondent resides in a border state, and a continuous variable measuring the distance to the Mexico–USA border – the site of the fictionalized news event – to a respondents' location.

Table 2. Full enumeration of treatment arms.

		<i>Tactics</i>	
		Confrontation	Encampment
<i>Characteristics</i>	Economic, Haiti	1	2
	Economic, Central America	3	4
	Political, Haiti	5	6
	Political, Central America	7	8

Estimation

We conduct a *t*-test with simple differences in means of our two dependent variables between treatment conditions. The conditions are crossed in a 2×2×2 factorial design, displayed in Table 2. Using a difference-in-means test of the first hypothesis – migrants’ tactics – we compare mean support for migration across cells 1, 3, 5, and 7 (confrontation) with the means of cells 2, 4, 6, and 8 (encampment). We expect the latter means to be larger. For the second hypothesis – migrants’ claim-making – with support for migration as the dependent variable, compares means across table cells 1, 2, 3, and 4 with the means of table cells 5, 6, 7, and 8. We expect mean support for migration in the second set of cells (political claims) to be higher than the mean in the first set of cells (economic claims). For the third hypothesis test – migrants’ out-group identity – we compare the mean support for migration across cells 1, 2, 5, and 6 (Haiti) with the mean of table cells 3, 4, 7, and 8 (Central America), expecting the second set to have a higher mean than the first. The expectations are reversed for the other dependent variable – support for deportation. Our difference in means tests compute standard errors through a two-sample *t*-test.

Randomization of treatment assignment should permit identification of average treatment effects through simple difference in means and without conditioning on covariates. We verify this by conducting balance tests in each sample. The randomization was successful, as indicated in Figures SI.B.2 and SI.B.3 in the Appendix. Nonetheless, our second hypothesis test approach is to employ linear regression models to estimate the coefficients for treatment effects in model specifications both with and without covariates. Our fully specified model, including each treatment arm and pretreatment covariates is:

$$\text{Migrant Support}_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{Tactic}_i + \beta_2 \text{Claim}_i + \beta_3 \text{Identity}_i + \delta X_i + \epsilon_i \quad (1)$$

where β_1 , β_2 , and β_3 are the coefficient estimates of interest for our three hypothesis tests, respectively, X_i is a

vector of individual-level pretreatment covariates, and ϵ_i is a robust error term. We also specify models without covariates, and with individual treatments.

Analysis

Figure 3 depicts estimated average treatment effects for the US survey from difference in means tests. The left panel (a) of Figure 3 displays estimates for migrant tactics. Results are unambiguous: migrant nonviolent resistance, compared to confrontations with security forces, increases the belief that migrants contribute to society and decreases support for deportation.

Support for deportation of undocumented migrants decreases by 0.18 on a five-point scale (about one-seventh of a standard deviation of the outcome variable), while the belief that migrants contribute to society increases by 0.15 on a five-point scale (about one-eighth of a standard deviation of the outcome variable).¹¹ It is important to note that these outcomes do not ask respondents about the deportation or potential contributions of the particular migrants involved in the incident. Rather, respondents are asked to share their views on migrants generally. This suggests that witnessing migrant nonviolent resistance in a single incident increases support for liberalized immigration policy compared to violent resistance.¹²

The right panel (Figure 3b) displays estimates for migrant characteristics. Migrant political claims do not significantly affect respondents’ support for deportation or a belief that migrants contribute to society compared to economic claims. The same holds for migrant identities. Respondents are not more likely to support deportation of migrants or believe that migrants contribute to society when presented with Central American migrants compared to Haitian migrants. Coefficient estimates from linear regression models are consistent, though the Central American migrant condition increases the belief in migrant contributions at the $p < 0.1$ level when included covariates increase the precision of coefficient estimates. The lack of support for Hypotheses 2a and 3 is surprising, and a departure from past findings on the drivers of public support for migrants and attitudes toward deportation.

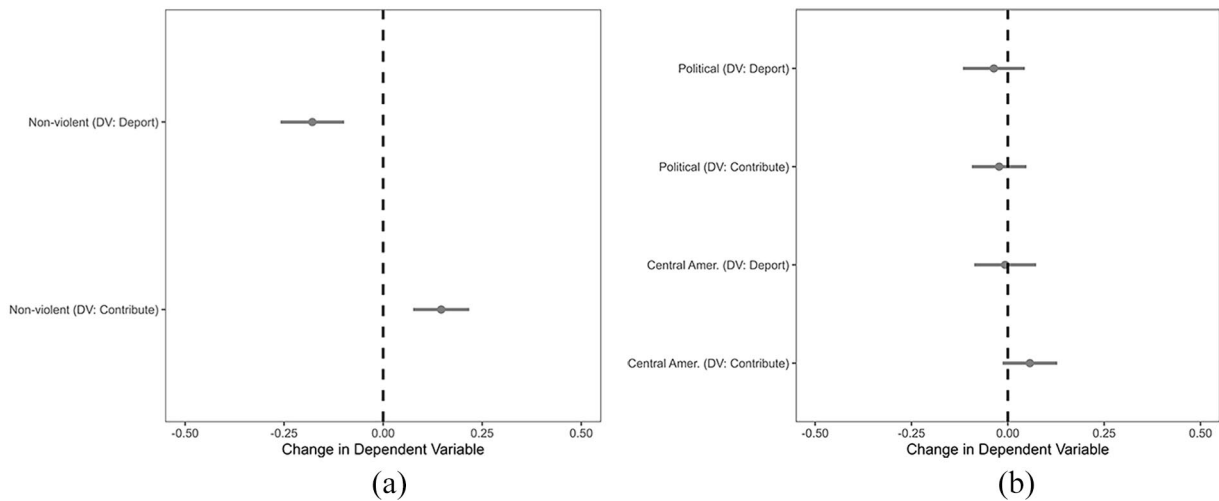


Figure 3. US Survey – average treatment effects of migrant tactics (a) and characteristics (b).

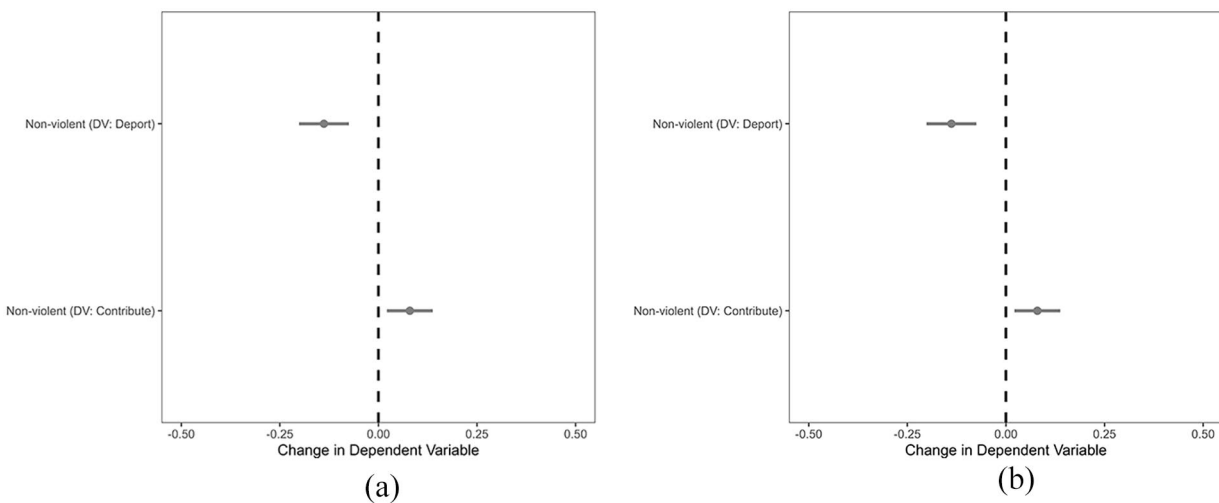


Figure 4. Mexico Survey – average treatment effects of migrant tactics (a) and characteristics (b).

Results for the Mexico survey, depicted in Figure 4, are strikingly similar to the US survey. For migrant tactics, the left panel (a) of Figure 4 shows patterns consistent with the US survey. Migrant nonviolent resistance decreases respondents' support for deportation and increases respondents' belief that migrants contribute to society, compared to migrant confrontations with security forces. Nonviolent resistance decreases support for deportation by 0.14 on a five-point scale (about one-seventh of a standard deviation of the outcome variable). Belief that migrants contribute to society increases by 0.08 on a five-point scale (only about one-twelfth of a standard deviation of the outcome variable).¹³ While these treatment effects are more modest than those in the US survey, they suggest nonviolent resistance can

shape public attitudes about migration beyond destination countries. Between the results of the two surveys, we affirm Hypothesis 1.

The right panel (b) of Figure 4 shows difference in means estimates for migrant characteristics. Migrant political claims, compared to economic claims, do not significantly reduce support for deportation or increase belief in migrant contributions. If anything, the estimates are signed in the opposite direction: Mexican respondents appeared to favor migrants making economic claims more than political claims.¹⁴ While the insignificant results support Hypothesis 1b, we must also compare the difference in means estimates with those in the US survey to determine if Mexican respondents reacted more favorably to economic migrants than US

respondents. A t -test comparing the treatment effects across samples returns a p -value of 0.05 for the support for deportation outcome: Mexican respondents were less likely to favor deportation of economic migrants compared to political migrants than US respondents.

Conditional effects of migrant nonviolent resistance

The significant effects of nonviolent resistance found in each survey may vary conditional on other treatments and respondent characteristics, particularly with migrants as contentious actors. Manekin and Mitts (2022) show that ethnic identities moderate the effects of nonviolent resistance: ethnic in-groups win support for using these tactics, while more racialized out-groups gain no advantage from nonviolent resistance over confrontation. For respondent characteristics, literature on attitudes toward immigration suggests that partisanship and proximity to the border should condition attitudes toward migrants and deportation (Cortina, 2020; Pinson and Simmons, 2022).

Nonviolent resistance across migrant identities

We might expect that some migrants receive more support than others when using nonviolent tactics. Manekin and Mitts (2022) argue that the effectiveness of nonviolent resistance is diminished when the contentious actors are from racialized out-groups. These out-groups are perceived by members of the in-group as inherently violent, criminal, and untrustworthy. The moral appeal of nonviolent tactics, under this argument, does not mitigate the in-group's predisposition to perceive the out-group as violent criminals. Nonviolent tactics therefore do not generate public support for out-groups compared to violent tactics.

In contrast, we contend that nonviolent and therefore less threatening tactics win more public support than violent tactics – at least in the context of migration – regardless of the contentious actors' out-group identity. Though the public may have less baseline support for more racialized out-groups, or even perceive them as more violent *ex ante*, their support still increases when such groups use nonviolent tactics. This is because out-groups are able to use nonviolent tactics to cast their claims as a struggle for rights, a framing reproduced in sympathetic media coverage of nonviolent contention (Wasow, 2020). In a pre-registered test to adjudicate these expectations, we estimate a treatment-by-treatment interaction between the identity treatment and the tactic treatment.

We expect the interaction term to be statistically indistinguishable from zero. That is, nonviolent resistance by Central American migrants should decrease support for deportation and increase belief in migrants' contribution to society comparably to nonviolent resistance by Haitian migrants. This expectation contrasts with past findings with different, nonmigrant contentious actors that the public, at least in the United States, will show favoritism toward 'light raced immigrants' (Ostfeld, 2017: 32) and toward less-racialized actors in contentious events (Manekin and Mitts, 2022).

Figures 5 and 6 show that, in both the US and Mexico surveys, the effect of migrant nonviolent resistance does not vary whether the migrants in the contentious event are Central American (Honduran) or Haitian. Moreover, baseline differences in respondents' attitudes toward Central American and Haitian migrants do not significantly differ.¹⁵ We are confident that the identity treatment could detect effects of migrant racialization, given the migrants' declaration of their own identities in the vignette: Honduran migrants refer to themselves as Hispanic, and Haitian migrants refer to themselves as Black. To verify the robustness of this result, we subset each sample to include only the white respondents in relation to whom Central American migrants are less racialized than Haitian migrants. Among self-identified non-Hispanic white respondents in the USA and white respondents in Mexico, the effects of nonviolent resistance are consistent across the Central American and Haitian treatment conditions.¹⁶

Nonviolent resistance across partisanship and border proximity

While migrant nonviolent resistance decreases public support for deportation and increases beliefs in migrant contribution to society regardless of migrants' identities, changes in support could also depend on respondent characteristics. Past scholarship suggests that partisanship and proximity to migrants condition support for liberalized immigration policy (Cools et al., 2021; Cortina, 2020; Hangartner et al., 2019; Pinson and Simmons, 2022). As a test of whether the effects of migrant nonviolent resistance are conditional on partisanship (not pre-registered) or proximity (preregistered), we estimate the interaction between the tactic treatment and whether respondents expressed support for a right-wing party and whether respondents lived in a border state. For right-wing party support, we create an indicator that takes the value of 1 if the respondent supported the Republican Party in the United States or the National Action Party (PAN) in Mexico.

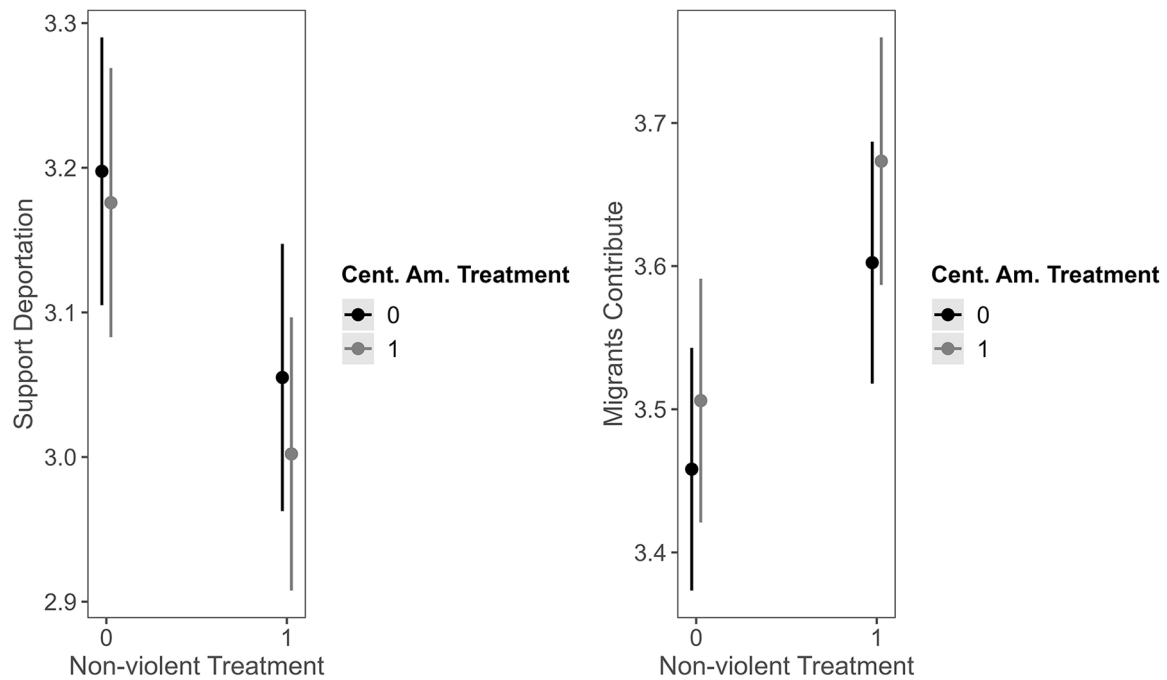


Figure 5. US Survey – the effect of migrant non-violent resistance does not vary by migrants' identity.

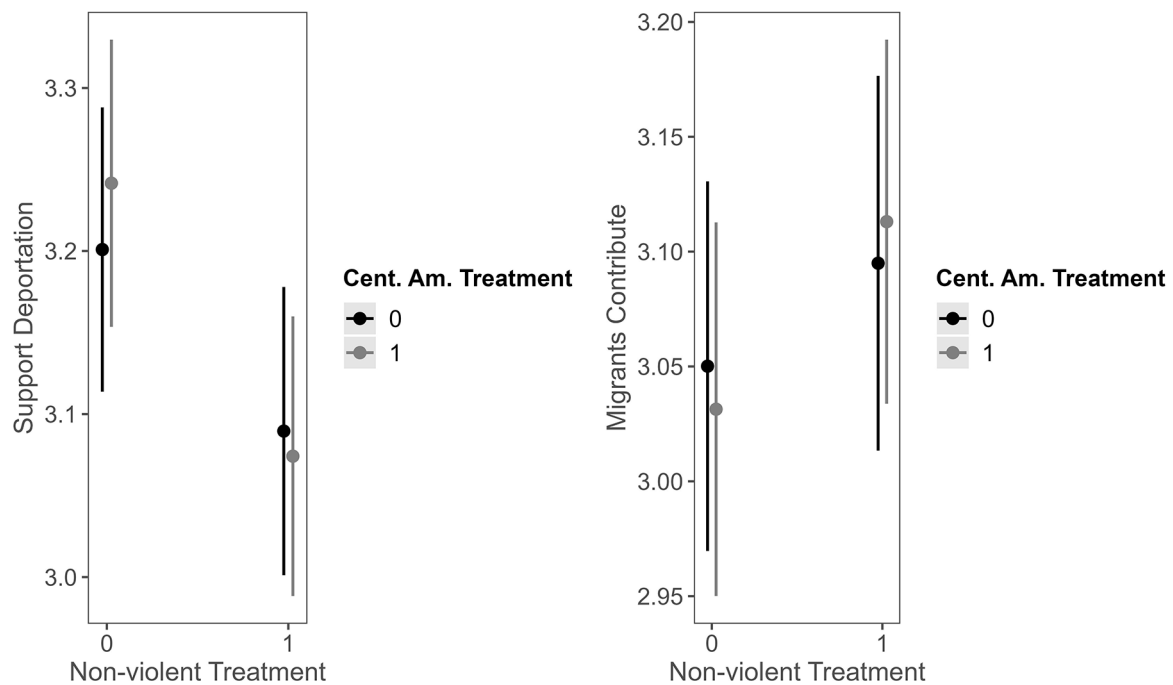


Figure 6. Mexico Survey – the effect of migrant non-violent resistance does not vary by migrants' identity.

We find no consistent evidence that the effects of nonviolent resistance vary by either partisanship or proximity. Border state respondents in Mexico exposed to nonviolent migrants are more likely to believe migrants contribute to society than non-border state respondents. However, these

respondents do not differentially change their support for deportation, and there are not similar patterns with US border state respondents.¹⁷ Results are comparable when using an alternative measure: proximity from respondent location to the nearest point along the Mexico–USA land border.

Perceptions of migrant criminality

If migrants can exercise agency to decrease public support for deportation by using nonviolent tactics, through what pathways might these tactics change attitudes toward policy? One possibility is that respondents are less likely to perceive migrants as criminally motivated if they refrain from confronting security forces at the border. We conduct a pre-registered test of whether respondents are less likely to attribute criminal intent to migrants who use nonviolent tactics. We ask a post-treatment question about respondents' beliefs about the motives of migrants in the incident, and expect the share of respondents believing the migrants had criminal intent to be lower in the nonviolent resistance treatment condition compared to the confrontation condition.

Results for this test diverge between the United States and Mexico survey samples. While there is no significant change in Mexican respondents' perceptions of migrant criminality when migrants use nonviolent tactics compared to violent tactics, US respondents are significantly less likely to ascribe criminal intent when reading about nonviolent migrants. While this finding suggests perceiving criminal intent is not necessary to shift policy attitudes in response to migrant nonviolent resistance, it does present another compelling implication. Figure 7 depicts an interaction between the nonviolent resistance treatment and respondent partisanship in the US survey. Republican respondents are two-thirds more likely than non-Republican respondents to assign a criminal motive to migrants who confront security forces (15% versus 9%). This difference disappears with respect to nonviolent migrants: 7% of Republicans and 6% of non-Republicans assign criminal motives in the nonviolent resistance condition.¹⁸

The combination of findings from heterogeneous effects of migrant nonviolent resistance by migrant identity and respondent characteristics paints a simple yet compelling picture. During contentious border events, when migrants choose tactics of nonviolent resistance rather than confrontation, they increase public support for liberalized immigration policy regardless of their identities, respondent partisanship, and respondent proximity to the border. They also may be perceived as less criminal, and can cause members of a party opposing immigration to adopt similar attitudes on this question as the rest of the public.

Discussion: Unexpected null findings

Our results partially contrast with expectations. Migrant nonviolent resistance (Hypothesis 1) robustly increases

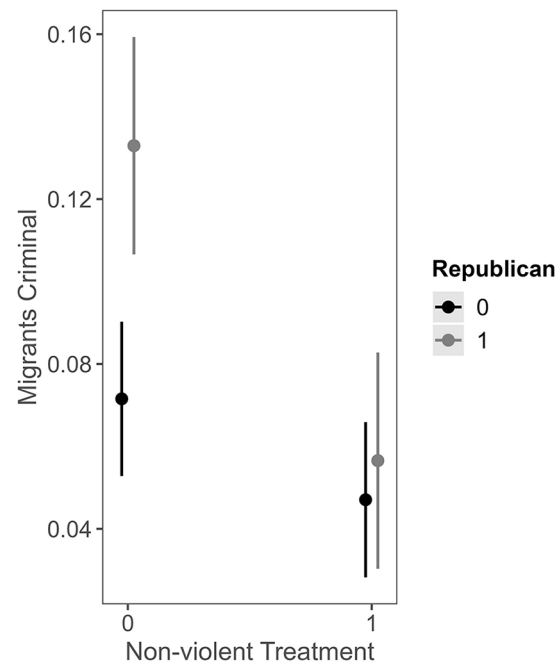


Figure 7. US Survey – Republican Respondents are more likely to assign a criminal motive to migrants who confront security forces.

public support for migration compared to migrant violent resistance. This treatment effect is not conditional on migrant identity, respondent partisanship, or respondent border proximity. We did not detect a significant treatment effect for migrant claims (Hypothesis 2) or migrant identity (Hypothesis 3). It is worth noting, however, for Hypothesis 3, that the results for migrant identity are generally in the direction the hypothesis predicts. Full results for tests of migrant identity effects in the US survey (Table SI.C.3) are signed in the expected direction, with Central American migrants having less average support for deportation and higher beliefs in contributions. In one model (Column 4), the effect of Central American migrants compared to Haitian migrants on beliefs in migrant contributions to society is positive and significant at the $p < 0.1$ level. In the Mexico survey (Table SI.C.7), the results are not all signed in the expected direction.

It is also worth noting that our null findings for treatment effect heterogeneity by partisanship and border proximity do not imply that these variables are not determinants of immigration attitudes. Rather, our findings suggest they do not moderate the treatment effect of nonviolent migrant tactics. In Tables SI.E.1 and SI.E.2, we present descriptive results that affirm the significance of partisanship and border proximity – particularly in the US case – for immigration attitudes. In the US, Republicans

are significantly more likely to support migrant deportation and are significantly less likely to believe migrants contribute to society. Respondents living closer to the Mexico–USA border are significantly less likely to support migrant deportation. In Mexico, PAN supporters are more likely to support deportation, while at the $p < 0.1$ level, respondents living closer to the border are less likely to support deportation. These findings are consistent with past findings of how partisanship and border proximity correspond to immigration attitudes.

With these qualifications, we are still left with the remaining question of why the treatment effects for migrant tactics (Hypothesis 1) are so much stronger than the effects for migrant identity and claims (Hypotheses 2 and 3). To us, this suggests that contentious events in the context of migration and border politics foreground the tactics of the participating actors, and diminish the salience of migrant attributes. The primacy of tactics makes contentious events by migrants comparable to other domains of contentious politics (Chenoweth and Stephan, 2011). The salience of migrant attributes is greater when respondents are asked to evaluate the admission of migrants as a state-centered policy choice rather than an interaction between migrants and the state (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014). Some past work, particularly Sirin et al. (2016), evaluates public attitudes toward migrant interaction with the state in the context of immigration detention centers. The authors find that white and Latino respondents had harsher reactions against Black detainees than Latino detainees. However, the dependent variable of interest is group empathy rather than the generalized policy attitudes of interest in the present project. Taken together, these results suggest that, in a contentious migrant–state interaction, migrant identity may still affect direct attitudes toward migrants in the interaction, but that tactics exert a stronger influence on generalized attitudes.

Conclusion

Migrants can win public support through the tactics used to attempt border crossings. The results from survey experiments in the United States and Mexico show the effectiveness of nonviolent resistance – compared to violence – in changing public attitudes toward deportation and the belief that migrants contribute to society. Encampments of migrants peacefully making claims win more support than migrants confronting security forces with violent tactics. That migrants' nonviolent tactics increase support for liberalized immigration policy compared to violence, even among those most predisposed to

favor the deportation of migrants on the political right, suggests two key takeaways from this research. First, civil resistance works. It can undermine the 'pillars of support' for deportation of migrants just as it undermines pillars of support for repressive regimes (Chenoweth, 2021). Second, civil resistance can break the 'hidden consensus' in public support for migration (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015) and the decades-long 'securitization' of migration in developed democracies (Huysmans, 2000). Migrants typically disfavored by the public – such as ethnic outgroups – can exercise agency through staging contentious action and making claims against governments.

Identifying similar effects of migrant nonviolent resistance in both the United States and Mexico points to the findings' external validity. However, the mechanism through which nonviolent tactics win public support may differ between contexts. Perceptions of migrant criminality, for example, decreased in the United States but not Mexico with the nonviolent resistance treatments. The effectiveness of migrants' tactics in different settings could depend on the underlying attitudes – such as the belief that migrants are criminals – conditioning support for migration in the first place. Additionally, repeated exposure to migrant crossings could harden attitudes and render them unchanged after exposure to a single vignette of migrant tactics. In Europe, which experienced a high-profile and heavily covered refugee and asylum-seeker crisis in 2014, the public may have been saturated with these images and less likely to be affected by the treatments here. Finally, the ambiguities and frequent reversals of policy along the Mexico–USA border in the late 2010s and early 2020s could have created unique conditions for the variation in available tactics for migrants: encampments or confrontations. In other contexts, as when Belarusian authorities effectively forced migrants across the Polish border in 2021, migrants may lack agency to choose nonviolent encampments to make their claims.

This project also does not consider how attitudes toward migrants are determined in part by political elites' exploitation of ethnic and origin-country stereotypes (Flores and Schachter, 2018). Political elites employ nativist rhetoric to inflame anti-migrant attitudes. This rhetoric heightens cultural threat perceptions, and boosts the political fortunes of xenophobic political parties (Hangartner et al., 2019). Scenes of migrant groups attempting border crossings are increasingly the backdrop on which nativist rhetoric and perceptions of migrant threat occur. The findings in this research suggest that, while opportunistic demagogues may frame these crossings as a horde of violent out-group members

sapping resources from their destination countries, there are two ways in which these efforts are limited. First, to the extent that such rhetoric focuses on out-group identity and economic motives, it may not reduce public support for migrants. Second, to the extent that such rhetoric focuses on migrant violence, advocates for migrants can counter-frame their tactics as peaceful and non-confrontational to win public support.

In the 21st century, migrants have taken on more consciously their roles and agency as political actors. With global migration flows growing, and native-born populations in developed countries of the Global North declining, migrants will become an increasingly established feature of contentious politics. Future research on migrants as contentious actors could study their tactics, messages, and sequences of interactions with each other and security forces throughout their series of movements. Scholars should also study borders as sites of contention. In this way, contentious politics research can dialogue with the emerging 'border orientation' in political science (Simmons and Kenwick, 2021).

Replication data

The dataset, codebook, and do-files for the empirical analysis in this article, as well as the Online Appendix, can be found at <http://www.prio.org/jpr/datasets>.

Acknowledgements

The authors thank Rebecca Cordell, Tobias Heinrich, Javier Osorio, Anna Pechenkina, Tamar Mitts, Matthew Wright, participants in the Political Science Research Workshop at Carnegie Mellon University, the 2022 American Political Science Association meeting, the 2022 Online Peace Science Colloquium, from the University of Arizona, and our anonymous reviewers for helpful comments. Jordyn Gilliard and Jesse Jenkins provided excellent research assistance. The study was approved by the University of Arizona Institutional Review Board.

Declaration of conflicting interests

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

Daniel Arnon acknowledges support from the University of Arizona.

ORCID iD

Pearce Edwards  <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-7990-2247>

Notes

1. Steinhilper notes that ethnographic research participants self-identified as migrants, addressing concerns that this is a pejorative term.
2. Online Appendix A provides more illustrative examples of migrant claim-making from other regions and borders besides the Mexico–USA border.
3. Sociological and anthropological studies in Europe are an exception.
4. There are exceptions to this expectation, such as Hopkins (2015), who finds no difference in migrant racialization and attitudes toward immigration policy.
5. Encounters in 2021 exceeded 500,000, the highest of any border sector.
6. The only un-registered test, a test of heterogeneous effects by partisanship, is noted below.
7. In total, its details were checked against a sample of more than 50 major newspaper accounts of border events across major newspapers from 2016 to 2022.
8. The confrontation condition closely mirrors the details of a November 2018 event near San Diego mentioned above.
9. These factual manipulation check pass rates may be so high because inattentive respondents had already been screened out during the pre-treatment phase.
10. Because no migrants in the vignette are from Mexico, and because the question speaks to border crossings generally, this question validly measures attitudes toward deportation in both Mexico and the United States surveys.
11. Full results are in Table SI.C.1. A robustness test with an alternate measure of deportation support based on its selection from a list of policy options is in Table SI.C.4.
12. Full results are in Tables SI.C.2 and SI.C.3.
13. Full results are in SI.C.5. A robustness test with an alternate measure of deportation support based on its selection from a list of policy options is in Table SI.C.8.
14. Full results are in Tables SI.C.6 and SI.C.7.
15. Full results are in Tables SI.D.1 and SI.D.2.
16. Full results are in Tables SI.D.3 and SI.D.4.
17. Full results are in Tables SI.D.5 to SI.D.8.
18. Note that the treatment effects are significant among Republicans and non-Republicans alike. Full results are in Tables SI.D.9 and SI.D.10.

References

- Abbott J (2018) How the migrant caravan sparked a movement. Available at: <https://wagingnonviolence.org/2018/11/how-migrant-caravan-sparked-movement/> (accessed 8 August 2022).

- Bayly T (2022) In focus: Migrants languish in Mexico's chaotic immigration system. *Cronkite News*, 22 September. Available at: <https://cronkitenews.azpbs.org/2022/09/22/tapachula-migrants-protest-mexico-immigration-policies/> (accessed 10 September 2024).
- Brewer S, Tejada L and Meyer M (2022) Struggling to survive: The situation of asylum seekers in Tapachula, Mexico. Research report, Advocacy for Human Rights in the Americas, Washington, DC, June. Available at: <https://www.wola.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/FINAL-Struggling-to-Survive-Asylum-Seekers-in-Tapachula.pdf> (accessed 8 August 2022).
- Brutger R, Kertzer JD, Renshon J, et al. (2023) Abstraction and detail in experimental design. *American Journal of Political Science* 67(4): 979–995.
- Chenoweth E (2021) *Civil Resistance: What Everyone Needs to Know*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Chenoweth E and Cunningham KG (2023) Guest editors' introduction: Nonviolent resistance and its discontents. *Journal of Peace Research* 60(1): 3–8.
- Chenoweth E and Stephan M (2011) *Why Civil Resistance Works: The Strategic Logic of Nonviolent Conflict*. New York, NY: Columbia University Press.
- Cools S, Finseraas H and Rogeberg O (2021) Local immigration and support for anti-immigration parties: A meta-analysis. *American Journal of Political Science* 65(4): 988–1006.
- Cortina J (2020) From a distance: Geographic proximity, partisanship, and public attitudes toward the US–Mexico border wall. *Political Research Quarterly* 73(3): 740–754.
- Cunningham KG, Dahl M and Fruge A (2017) Strategies of resistance: Diversification and diffusion. *American Journal of Political Science* 61(3): 591–605.
- Dahlum S, Pinckney J and Wig T (2023) Moral logics of support for nonviolent resistance: Evidence from a cross-national survey experiment. *Comparative Political Studies* 56(3): 326–362.
- Davenport C, Soule SA and Armstrong DA (2011) Protesting while black? The differential policing of American activism, 1960 to 1990. *American Sociological Review* 76(1): 152–178.
- Dobbins J, Sullivan E and Sandoval E (2021) Surge leaves 9,000 migrants crammed under a Texas bridge. *New York Times*, 16 September. Available at: <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/09/16/us/texas-migrants-del-rio.html> (accessed 8 August 2022).
- Edwards P and Arnon D (2021) Violence on many sides: Framing effects on protest and support for repression. *British Journal of Political Science* 51(2): 488–506.
- Fitzgerald J, Curtis KA and Corliss CL (2012) Anxious publics: Worries about crime and immigration. *Comparative Political Studies* 45(4): 477–506.
- Flores RD and Schachter A (2018) Who are the 'illegals'? The social construction of illegality in the United States. *American Sociological Review* 83(5): 839–868.
- Getmansky A, Sinmazdemir T and Zeitsoff T (2019) The allure of distant war drums: Refugees, geography, and foreign policy preferences in Turkey. *Political Geography* 74: 102036.
- Gramlich J and Scheller A (2021) What's happening at the US–Mexico border in 7 charts. Report, Pew Research Center, Washington, DC, March. Available at: <https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2021/11/09/whats-happening-at-the-u-s-mexico-border-in-7-charts/> (accessed 26 July 2022).
- Hainmueller J and Hopkins DJ (2014) Public attitudes toward immigration. *Annual Review of Political Science* 17: 225–249.
- Hainmueller J and Hopkins DJ (2015) The hidden American immigration consensus: A conjoint analysis of attitudes toward immigrants. *American Journal of Political Science* 59(3): 529–548.
- Hangartner D, Dinas E, Marbach M, et al. (2019) Does exposure to the refugee crisis make natives more hostile? *American Political Science Review* 113(2): 442–455.
- Hellwig T and Sinno A (2017) Different groups, different threats: Public attitudes towards immigrants. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 43(3): 339–358.
- Hood MV and Morris IL (1998) Give us your tired, your poor, . . . but make sure they have a green card: The effects of documented and undocumented migrant context on Anglo opinion toward immigration. *Political Behavior* 20(1): 1–15.
- Hopkins DJ (2015) The upside of accents: Language, intergroup difference, and attitudes toward immigration. *British Journal of Political Science* 45(3): 531–557.
- Huysmans J (2000) The European Union and the securitization of migration. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies* 38(5): 751–777.
- Klandermans B and van Stekelenburg J (2019) Identity formation in street demonstrations. In: Stets JE and Serpe RT (eds) *Identities in Everyday Life*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 309–327.
- Lauvergnier C (2019) African migrants trapped in Mexico protest for right to travel to USA. *France 24: The Observers*, 27 August. Available at: <https://observers.france24.com/en/20190826-mexico-african-migrants-trapped-protest-journey> (accessed 8 August 2022).
- McAdam D, Tarrow S and Tilly C (2001) *Dynamics of Contention*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- McKay FH, Thomas SL and Kneebone S (2012) 'It would be okay if they came through the proper channels': Community perceptions and attitudes toward asylum seekers in Australia. *Journal of Refugee Studies* 25(1): 113–133.
- Madrigal G and Soroka S (2023) Migrants, caravans, and the impact of news photos on immigration attitudes. *International Journal of Press/Politics* 28(1): 49–69.
- Manekin D and Mitts T (2022) Effective for whom? Ethnic identity and nonviolent resistance. *American Political Science Review* 116(1): 161–180.
- Maoz I and McCauley C (2008) Threat, dehumanization, and support for retaliatory aggressive policies. *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 52(1): 93–116.
- Onraet E, Van Hiel A, Valcke B, et al. (2021) Reactions towards asylum seekers in the Netherlands: Associations

- with right-wing ideological attitudes, threat and perceptions of asylum seekers as legitimate and economic. *Journal of Refugee Studies* 34(2): 1695–1712.
- Ostfeld M (2017) The backyard politics of attitudes toward immigration. *Political Psychology* 38(1): 21–37.
- Pearlman W (2021) Mobilizing from scratch: Large-scale collective action without preexisting organization in the Syrian uprising. *Comparative Political Studies* 54(10): 1786–1817.
- Pew Research Center (2020) American Trends Panel Wave 68 (dataset). Available at: <https://www.pewresearch.org/dataset/american-trends-panel-wave-68/> (accessed 8 August 2024).
- Pinson LE and Simmons BA (2022) Symbolism and polarization in American public opinion: The case of border security. Working paper.
- Pop-Eleches G, Robertson G and Rosenfeld B (2022) Protest participation and attitude change: Evidence from Ukraine's Euromaidan revolution. *Journal of Politics* 84(2): 625–638.
- Raleigh C, Linke A, Hegre H, et al. (2010) Introducing ACLED: An armed conflict location and event dataset: Special data feature. *Journal of Peace Research* 47(5): 651–660.
- Rosenberger S, Stern V and Merhaut N (2018) *Protest Movements in Asylum and Deportation*. Cham, Germany: Springer.
- Schaftenaar S (2017) How (wo)men rebel: Exploring the effect of gender equality on nonviolent and armed conflict onset. *Journal of Peace Research* 54(6): 762–776.
- Sides J and Citrin J (2007) European opinion about immigration: The role of identities, interests and information. *British Journal of Political Science* 37(3): 477–504.
- Siegler K (2022) There are protests along the US–Mexico border after judge blocks ending title 42. *NPR*, 25 May. Available at: <https://www.npr.org/2022/05/25/1101141269/there-are-protests-along-the-u-s-mexico-border-after-judge-blocks-ending-title-4> (accessed 16 July 2022).
- Simmons BA and Kenwick MR (2021) Border orientation in a globalizing world. *American Journal of Political Science* 66(4): 853–870.
- Sirin CV, Valentino NA and Villalobos JD (2016) Group empathy theory: The effect of group empathy on US intergroup attitudes and behavior in the context of immigration threats. *Journal of Politics* 78(3): 893–908.
- Solomon DB (2021) White House condemns border guard use of whip-like cord against Haitian migrants. *Reuters*, 21 September. Available at: <https://www.reuters.com/world/us/us-homeland-security-chief-heads-border-removal-migrant-camp-accelerates-2021-09-20/> (accessed 24 June 2022).
- Steinert-Threlkeld Z (2017) Spontaneous collective action: Peripheral mobilization during the Arab Spring. *American Political Science Review* 111(2): 379–403.
- Steinhilper E (2018) Mobilizing in transnational contentious spaces: Linking relations, emotions and space in migrant activism. *Social Movement Studies* 17(5): 574–591.
- Valentino NA, Soroka SN, Iyengar S, et al. (2019) Economic and cultural drivers of immigrant support worldwide. *British Journal of Political Science* 49(4): 1201–1226.
- Villegas P (2022) Migrants stuck at Mexico's southern border sew their mouths shut in protest. *Washington Post*, 16 February. Available at: <https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/2022/02/16/migrants-mexico-protest/> (accessed 8 August 2022).
- Volk L (2021) Enacting citizenship: A case study of a Syrian refugee protest in Germany. *Anthropology of the Middle East* 16(1): 92–110.
- Von Hermanni H and Neumann R (2019) 'Refugees welcome': The interplay between perceived threats and general concerns on the acceptance of refugees – a factorial survey approach in Germany. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 45(3): 349–374.
- Wang DJ and Soule SA (2016) Tactical innovation in social movements: The effects of peripheral and multi-issue protest. *American Sociological Review* 81(3): 517–548.
- Ward DG (2019) Public attitudes toward young immigrant men. *American Political Science Review* 113(1): 264–269.
- Washington Post-Reforma (2019) Washington Post-Reforma Mexico poll July 9–14, 2019. Available at: <https://www.washingtonpost.com/context/washington-post-reforma-mexico-poll/801f58a6-ab67-4da6-bd1d-39659863c4c7/> (accessed 20 August 2022).
- Wasow O (2020) Agenda seeding: How 1960s black protests moved elites, public opinion and voting. *American Political Science Review* 114(3): 638–659.
- Wright M and Citrin J (2011) Saved by the stars and stripes? Images of protest, salience of threat, and immigration attitudes. *American Politics Research* 39(2): 323–343.
- Zhou YY and Grossman G (2021) When refugee exposure increases incumbent support through development: Evidence from Uganda. OSF Preprints, 7 October. Available at: <https://osf.io/preprints/osf/94tpy> (accessed 23 March 2022).

PEARCE EDWARDS, b. 1991, PhD (Emory University, 2021); Assistant Professor, Louisiana State University; current main interests: authoritarian politics, repression, contentious politics.

DANIEL ARNON, b. 1984, PhD (Emory University, 2020); Assistant Professor, University of Arizona; current main interests: contentious politics, repression, human rights.